

The Novel <i>The Big Picture</i>

A. THE NOVEL IS PEOPLE.

1. Identify the major characters and the subordinate characters.
2. Detailed study of characters should include:
 - a. Who is the protagonist of the novel?
 - b. Point out how the protagonist is developed, what its motivation is, and explain its attitude, philosophy, and personality traits.
 - c. Characterize the remaining people in the novel in a similar fashion.

B. THE NOVEL IS SETTING.

1. What is the geographical setting of the novel? Describe and provide a map if possible.
2. What is the historical setting of the novel? Explain.
3. What is the atmosphere of the novel? Explain.
4. Discuss the importance of setting in the novel. Remember, setting is often used for more than a physical backdrop to the action.
 - a. Setting may suggest mood.
 - b. Setting may help delineate character.
 - c. Setting may reveal the novelist's attitude.

C. THE NOVEL IS ACTION.

1. Discuss the plot of the novel. Include a thorough analysis of the following elements:
 - a. What are the major conflicts in the novel? Name them and discuss their significance and interrelationships.
 - b. What are the major complicating incidents in the novel?
 - c. How is suspense developed and maintained? Commonly used devices include conflict, mystery, an apparently insoluble problem, foreshadowing, and a see-saw of victories and defeats for the protagonist.
 - d. What is the climax of the novel? What is the outcome? Explain.
2. Are there subplots in the novel?
 - a. Describe them.
 - b. How are they related to the main plot?
 - c. What purpose do they serve in the novel?
3. How is the plot developed?
 - a. Do any coincidences occur in the novel? How does the novelist make them credible?
 - b. Explain the role fate plays in the novel.
 - c. Classify the novel as either comic or tragic.

D. THE NOVEL IS TRUTH.

1. A good novel conveys universality.
 - a. What is the controlling purpose of the novel? Explain.
 - b. Does the novel contain supplementary themes? Elaborate on them.
2. It is comforting to learn from the mistakes of others through the reading of novels. What mistakes are evident in this novel and what can be learned from them? In other words, does the novel contain a moral?

E. THE NOVEL IS STYLE.

1. What point of view is used to tell the story? Explain its advantages.
2. What is the author's tone (its attitude toward its material)?
3. Does novelist create pathos or bathos in its novel? Explain.
4. Does the author use any of the following literary devices?
 - a. Imagery: Are figures of speech or vivid description used? If so, for what purpose(s)?
 - b. Symbolism: Are symbols used to reinforce meaning or to add explosive force to the narrative? Give examples and discuss their importance.
 - c. Irony: Discuss the use of irony. Give examples and explain their significance.